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Household relationships • The domestic cycle

Replacement. After some 25 years of autonomy the household will have shrunk to a strength of two; children will have left to form their own autonomous households and the couple's parents will have died. At an age of more than 40, the husband will be an old man with failing strength and sight, no longer fit for hunting large game with much hope of success. To an increasing extent, he must turn to such minor semispecialization as handcrafts and child minding. In return for these favors, he receives gifts of meat from younger hunters during the seasons when the band is camped together. In the reduced household with only two mouths to feed, the wife can manage her subsistence tasks in years of normal plenty but will be hard-pushed in drought years. It is at this stage that the elderly couple may turn to their children for support and attach themselves to the household of a daughter or son and follow them into winter isolation, when the reduced field of interaction and reciprocation of favors restricts the contribution that the old man's efforts make to the household diet. Among the G/wi, death follows the onset of senility by only a few months, so the period of semiparasitic dependence of the elderly is brief.

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Household relationships

The conjugal dyad. Public display of affection between husband and wife is considered childish and appropriate only to young couples in their first years of marriage. Older autonomous couples make no apparent effort to spend free time together. Their conversation in company is impersonal, almost cool, and their greetings, even after fairly prolonged absence, are offhand and devoid of any show of pleasure. However, the bonds of affection are strong,

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and in private conversations with my wife and me many informants revealed intense emotional ties with their spouses.

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Sexual Stimulation

The strength of the conjugal bond is also indicated by formal aspects of the social structure:

1. To some extent there is a merging of the separate social identities of the spouses on marriage. They assume a common residence and adopt one another's kin as affines. The husband comes under the tutelage of his wife's father in a dependent role, which approximates that of a child in the family. The joking/respect status of the husband within his wife's kin group is the same as hers and vice versa.

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2. In the menarchial ceremonies, the obvious symbolizing and the overt emphasis of the unity of a married couple and, within that unity, their complementarity and interdependence are clear evidence that the conjugal dyad is regarded as a unique and irreducible relationship.

3. The spouses have mutual sexual rights, which are exclusive to the extent that the community will defend these rights against any person who, by overt act or indiscretion, implies a claim to share them. This is the only wrong for which an aggrieved person is permitted physical violence upon a nonmember of his or her household. In polygynous marriages, sexual rights are guarded not only against outsiders, but the equality of those rights is also jealously guarded by the co-wives.

4. Although common parenthood of children is possibly shared by successive spouses, and is approximated to by classificatory parents, it is a status unique to the extant conjugal dyad.

5. The husband's susceptibility to danger during his wife's menstrual periods is a further indication of the strength and closeness of their relationship.

6. Once the couple has attained independent status, the husband is vicariously liable for any malicious damage inflicted by his wife and is obliged to make reparation for damage occasioned by her carelessness. He is also liable for damage done by his children, including a dependent son-in-law. This illustrates the extent to which the identities of husband and wife are merged, as liability is transferred on marriage to the man's father-in-law for the duration of the initial phase of the domestic cycle.

7. An adult married man does not normally receive food from any woman other than his wife, and a married woman does not normally give food to any man other than her husband. In the games that children play in imitation of adults, the girl who plays at cooking for a boy is his wife. To use prepared food as a symbol of the conjugal dyad is, among hunters and gatherers to whom food is of such great importance, an indication of the weight attached to the relationship.

*755 Prospect Street
New Haven, CT 06511*

General Inquiries:  hraf@yale.edu

Issues and Bugs:  hraf-support@yale.edu



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